

TrustLedger SRM Intelligence Architecture Review — Part 4

Methodology & Framework Architecture

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Review status

Part 4 defines how professional SRM methodologies and frameworks should relate to TrustLedger's stable operational and intelligence architecture. Its purpose is to prevent methodology lock-in while allowing TrustLedger to support a growing and changing SRM profession. This is a strategic architecture reference and does not authorise implementation.

1. Purpose of Part 4

Parts 1–3 established the Core Intelligence Model, Capability Map, and Intelligence Architecture & Traceability Model. Part 4 addresses the next architectural question:

How can TrustLedger support multiple professional methodologies without making any one methodology part of the permanent platform core?

2. The Central Principle

TrustLedger owns the evidence, context, relationships and operational reality. Methodologies provide analytical lenses through which that reality can be assessed.

A methodology may change, be replaced, coexist with another methodology, or become obsolete. The underlying stakeholder, engagement, commitment, issue, evidence and outcome records should remain usable.

3. What Is a Methodology?

For TrustLedger purposes, a methodology is a defined professional approach for examining, assessing, interpreting or managing stakeholder-related conditions.

It may contain concepts, dimensions, assessment criteria, rules, procedures, scoring approaches, interpretation guidance, evidence requirements and decision-support outputs.

A methodology is therefore an analytical lens—not the underlying reality.

4. Methodology vs Core Data

Core data: Stakeholder, Project, Place, Relationship, Engagement, Commitment, Issue, Evidence, Decision, Action and Outcome.

Methodology: the way those records are examined or assessed.

For example, a Stakeholder record should not be redesigned because a new influence-analysis method is introduced. The method should use the existing Stakeholder and Relationship information.

5. Methodology vs Intelligence

A methodology describes *how* an assessment is performed. Intelligence is the resulting decision-useful interpretation.

Example: a power-interest framework may classify a stakeholder as high power/high interest. That classification is a methodological output. TrustLedger intelligence may then combine that result with current capacity, engagement history,

relationship condition and project timing to produce a more contextual signal.

6. Methodology vs Rule

Rule: a defined logical condition, such as “flag a commitment approaching its due date.”

Methodology: a professional framework defining what dimensions should be assessed and how they should be interpreted.

Intelligence: the contextual result produced from evidence, method and interpretation.

Rules may implement parts of methodologies, but a methodology should not be reduced to a collection of isolated rules.

7. Methodology vs Model

Model: an analytical mechanism that transforms inputs into an output.

Methodology: the broader professional approach governing purpose, inputs, assessment, interpretation and use of outputs.

A methodology may use one or more models, but the model is not necessarily the methodology itself.

8. Methodology vs Configuration

Configuration changes how an established capability behaves for a project, organisation or user. A methodology changes the analytical framework used to assess a condition.

Configuration example: a client changes the categories used for stakeholder roles.

Methodology example: a client adopts a formal stakeholder-salience assessment.

9. The Methodology Contract

A TrustLedger methodology should conceptually declare a standard contract:

Identity: name, owner and purpose.

Version: methodology version and effective date.

Scope: what it is intended to assess.

Inputs: required TrustLedger records, evidence and contextual information.

Dimensions: factors assessed.

Logic: rules, procedures or analytical approach.

Outputs: classifications, assessments, signals or intelligence inputs.

Evidence requirements: what supports the assessment.

Limitations: known boundaries and uncertainty.

Governance: approval, ownership, review and retirement conditions.

10. Methodology Lifecycle

Identify → Define → Review → Approve → Version → Deploy → Use → Evaluate → Revise → Retire

A methodology should have an explicit lifecycle. It should not become permanent simply because it was once implemented.

11. Methodology Admission

Before a methodology is introduced, TrustLedger should establish:

- professional purpose and problem addressed
- evidence of usefulness
- relationship to TrustLedger's strategic purpose
- required inputs

- expected outputs
- limitations and risks
- whether it belongs in TrustLedger or an external service
- whether it can operate without changing the stable core
- governance and ownership requirements

12. Methodology Classification

Methodologies can be classified conceptually as:

Core-supported: strongly aligned with TrustLedger's central purpose and likely to be widely used.

Optional: valuable but not universal.

Client-specific: required by a particular organisation or programme.

Experimental: under evaluation and not yet productised.

External: better provided by a specialist external system or professional service.

Retired: no longer supported as an active approach.

13. Multiple Methodologies Can Coexist

TrustLedger should allow more than one methodology to assess the same underlying stakeholder or relationship, provided their outputs remain identifiable and their assumptions are not silently mixed.

For example, one project may use a power-interest analysis for engagement planning, a social-risk methodology for risk assessment, and a TrustLedger-specific relationship-health model for ongoing monitoring.

14. Methodology Composition

Methodologies may be composed where professionally justified. One methodology may provide stakeholder prioritisation while another assesses participation quality and another assesses social risk.

The architecture should distinguish the individual methodology outputs from any later synthesis so that users can understand how a composite intelligence result was produced.

15. Methodology Versioning

Methodology outputs should be associated with the version of the methodology used to produce them.

If a methodology changes materially, future assessments should use the new version while historical assessments retain their original methodological context where appropriate.

This protects historical comparability and auditability.

16. Methodology Provenance

A methodology-derived assessment should answer:

Which methodology was used? Which version? On what evidence? At what time? For which subject? By whom or by which service? Under what assumptions?

This is part of the TrustLedger trust model. A score without provenance is weak intelligence.

17. Methodology Output Types

Possible outputs include:

- classifications

- dimensions and ratings
- qualitative assessments
- risk categories
- participation assessments
- relationship conditions
- prioritisation results
- signals
- recommendations
- intelligence inputs

The output type should be explicit so that a methodology result is not confused with a verified operational fact.

18. Scoring and Rating Guardrail

TrustLedger should avoid treating numerical scores as inherently more objective than qualitative assessments.

Where scoring is used, the methodology should define its scale, meaning, evidence requirements, limitations and interpretation. Users should be able to understand what a score represents and what it does not represent.

19. Qualitative Methodologies

Not all SRM knowledge should be forced into numerical scoring. Community engagement, indigenous/local knowledge, conflict analysis, relationship dynamics and professional judgement may require qualitative interpretation.

The methodology architecture should therefore support structured qualitative outputs alongside quantitative assessments.

20. Indigenous and Local Knowledge

IKS and local knowledge should be treated as a potential methodological and knowledge dimension rather than forced into generic scoring structures.

Where such knowledge is captured, TrustLedger should preserve source, context, provenance, consent/governance requirements where applicable, and the distinction between reported knowledge and independently verified fact.

21. Professional Judgement

Methodologies should not attempt to eliminate professional judgement where judgement is an inherent part of the practice.

The architecture should allow an assessor to record interpretation, rationale, uncertainty and professional judgement while preserving the underlying evidence.

22. Client-Specific Methodologies

Clients may have internal stakeholder frameworks, community engagement standards, social-risk matrices or governance models.

TrustLedger should accommodate legitimate client-specific methods through controlled configuration or methodology definitions rather than client-specific source-code forks wherever possible.

23. Methodology Independence

A methodology should be independently replaceable. Removing or retiring one methodology should not invalidate the underlying stakeholder, relationship, engagement, evidence or outcome records.

Methodology failure must never become core-data failure.

24. Methodology Interoperability

Methodologies should be able to consume common TrustLedger inputs and produce outputs that other intelligence services can reference.

This creates a common analytical ecosystem rather than isolated methodology silos.

25. Methodology and AI

AI may assist in applying, interpreting or comparing methodologies, but it should not silently redefine the methodology.

Where AI assists, the methodology, evidence and human review requirements should remain identifiable. AI-generated interpretations should not be presented as methodology-certified results unless the methodology explicitly permits and governs such use.

26. Methodology and External Professional Services

Some advanced methodologies may be delivered by consultants, specialist platforms or professional bodies rather than implemented natively in TrustLedger.

TrustLedger should be able to receive relevant outputs as evidence or intelligence inputs while preserving provenance and source ownership.

27. Methodology Marketplace — Future Possibility

A future TrustLedger ecosystem could potentially support a controlled library of approved methodologies, professional frameworks or sector-specific analytical packs.

This is a future architectural possibility, not a recommendation to build a marketplace now. The immediate requirement is simply to ensure the core architecture does not prevent such evolution.

28. Methodology Governance

Methodology governance should establish who can introduce, approve, modify, publish, suspend or retire a methodology.

Governance should consider professional validity, evidence quality, ethical implications, legal or regulatory constraints, client requirements and compatibility with TrustLedger's architectural principles.

29. Methodology Retirement

Retirement should not delete historical results. Instead, a methodology should become inactive for new use while historical assessments retain their provenance.

This permits professional practice to evolve without destroying the institutional memory of how earlier assessments were produced.

30. Methodology Architecture Pattern

TRUSTLEDGER CORE

↓

COMMON EVIDENCE + CONTEXT

↓

METHODOLOGY INPUT CONTRACT

↓

METHODOLOGY / RULES / MODELS

↓

METHOD OUTPUT

↓

INTELLIGENCE SYNTHESIS

↓

HUMAN GOVERNANCE

↓

DECISION / ACTION / OUTCOME

This pattern allows multiple methodologies to operate over the same underlying reality.

31. Methodology Admission Test

Before accepting a methodology into TrustLedger, ask:

1. Is the professional problem real and sufficiently evidenced?
2. Is the methodology relevant to stakeholder relationships, social performance, participation, trust or related project/community intelligence?
3. Can its inputs be linked to TrustLedger evidence and context?
4. Are its assumptions and limitations understood?
5. Can its outputs be explained and traced?
6. Can it coexist with other methodologies?
7. Can it be versioned and retired?
8. Can it operate without destabilising the core?

32. Methodology Anti-Patterns

Avoid:

- embedding one methodology directly into core stakeholder fields
- replacing facts with scores
- mixing outputs from different methodologies without provenance
- allowing AI to silently alter methodological logic
- creating client-specific code forks for ordinary methodological variation
- deleting historical assessments when a methodology changes
- assuming every emerging professional framework deserves productisation

33. What Part 4 Does Not Authorise

This document does not authorise building a methodology engine, methodology registry, scoring framework, marketplace, new DocTypes, AI methodology service, graph database, or new dashboard.

It defines the architectural principles that future implementation should respect.

34. Part 4 Conclusion

TrustLedger should be methodology-agnostic but methodology-capable.

The platform should provide a stable evidence, context and relationship foundation over which multiple professional methodologies can operate. Methodologies should be identifiable, versioned, explainable, governed, replaceable and traceable to evidence.

The core should represent reality. Methodologies should represent ways of understanding reality.

This establishes the final conceptual foundation needed for Part 5: **TrustLedger Target Intelligence Architecture & Build Blueprint**, which will translate Parts 1–4 into the final pre-build architectural decision set.

Appendix A — Methodology Classification Matrix

Element	Stable?	Extensible?	Purpose
TrustLedger core records	Yes	Carefully	Represent operational reality.
Evidence & provenance	Yes	Yes	Support traceability and trust.
Methodology definition	Conceptual contract	Yes	Describe professional analytical approach.
Methodology logic	No	Yes	Assess evidence/context according to method.
Methodology output	No	Yes	Provide assessment or intelligence input.
Scoring scale	No	Yes	Method-specific; must retain meaning and provenance.
Professional judgement	Principle	Yes	Preserve human interpretation and rationale.
AI assistance	Guardrail	Yes	Assist without silently redefining methodology.
Methodology lifecycle	Principle	Yes	Allow introduction, versioning and retirement.

Appendix B — Core Methodology Principle

Build the architecture for methodological diversity before building individual methodologies.

The purpose is not to capture every SRM framework. It is to ensure that validated professional approaches can be introduced without destabilising the TrustLedger core.

Architectural boundary: This document is strategic reference guidance. It does not authorise implementation.